

SOUTHERN LATITUDES

THE STARS

In contrast to the sparkling skies of southern winter, the constellations of October evenings are mostly faint and unremarkable. One star

that stands out is 1st-magnitude Fomalhaut (see p.253), almost overhead in the constellation Piscis Austrinus. In the northwest sky is Altair (see p.252) in Aquila and,

high in the north, the Square of Pegasus. Between Pegasus and Fomalhaut lies Aquarius, the Water Carrier. More constellations with watery associations fill the eastern

part of the sky—Pisces, the Fish; Cetus, the Sea Monster or the Whale; and Eridanus, the River. The constellation Eridanus ends at the bright star Achernar, high in the south. The Small Magellanic Cloud (see p.310) is lower in the south, with the Large Magellanic Cloud (see p.310) now in view in the southeast. Canopus in Carina is also visible in the southeast for those farther south of the equator than 20°S.

DEEP-SKY OBJECTS

Tucana contains the second-best globular cluster in the sky, 47 Tucanae, or NGC 104, which is visible to the naked eye as a fuzzy star and appears impressive through binoculars. It covers the same area of sky as a full moon, near the Small Magellanic Cloud, but it lies much closer to us—about 15,000 light-years away—in our own galaxy. On the edge of the SMC, NGC 362 is another, fainter globular cluster, also in our galaxy.

October and November evenings are the best time for southern observers to view the Andromeda Galaxy, M31 (see pp.312–313), which lies low in the northern sky. Near it is another member of our Local Group of galaxies, M33, a smaller spiral galaxy that is less easy to see. In clear, dark skies, it can be glimpsed through binoculars or a low-power telescope as a large, rounded patch.

FAMILIAR ASTERISMS

The Cirlet of Pisces (left) and the Y-shaped Water Jar of Aquarius (right) are two easily recognizable star patterns in the October evening sky.

